

FRONTIER MODEL SLM BUYER PROFILE MEMO FOR ASHWIN

RECOMMENDATION

The Frontier Model SLM should start with closed-loop talent transformation and placement intermediaries.

The reason is simple: the first market should be chosen for the quality of the proof environment, not the size of the eventual market. Closed-loop intermediaries offer the best combination of planning pain, operational control, outcomes visibility, and repeatability. They are the strongest environment for proving that the model improves strategic workforce planning in a way that is commercially legible and capable of making the model smarter over time.

The recommended sequence is:

1. Closed-loop talent transformation and placement intermediaries
2. Employer-connected mission and workforce intermediaries
3. Community college apprenticeship and pathway programs
4. Large employers with strategic workforce planning pain
5. Higher-ed institutions with co-op and externship outcome closure
6. State workforce agencies and systems

WHY THIS ORDER WINS

1. Closed-loop intermediaries are the best proof market

This lane sits closest to a usable loop across talent assessment, pathway design, employer demand interpretation, deployment, and observable outcomes. That makes it the strongest place to validate the model and improve it quickly.

It is also a real category, not a single-account thesis. Revature is the clearest target, but SkillStorm, Dev10, Wiley Edge, FDM Group, Multiverse, and others show that the lane is deep enough to support a repeatable GTM motion.

2. Employer-connected workforce intermediaries are the best bridge market

This lane is not as strong as the first one for pure proof, but it is the strongest second move. It broadens the story from a commercial workforce intermediary thesis into a larger workforce-system thesis. It adds employer legitimacy, mobility logic, and pathway relevance.

Year Up / YUPRO and Per Scholas are the clearest examples. This is the lane that helps early proof become legible to a wider set of institutional buyers.

3. Community college pathways are the best higher-ed-adjacent expansion lane

This lane preserves occupational specificity, employer linkage, and category repeatability better than generic higher education. It is the most practical way to begin expanding into institution-based pathway systems after proof and bridge-market entry.

4. Large employers are the strongest scale market, but not the best starting market

Large employers likely offer the largest direct TAM, highest ACVs, and richest KPI-level outcomes data in theory. But they also come with harder data access, slower proof cycles, heavier integration burden, and a higher risk that early wins become bespoke rather than reusable.

This makes them an important scale market, but not the cleanest first proof market.

5. Higher-ed with co-op / externship closure is high-quality but narrower

Institutions like Northeastern and Drexel are compelling because they partially solve higher ed's usual outcome-closure problem. But the category appears more dependent on outliers and

- How directly does the SLM solve it?
- How valuable is the resulting proof environment?
- How accessible is the data needed to improve the model?
- How quickly can real outcomes be observed?
- How repeatable is the GTM motion across similar buyers?
- How attractive is the lane commercially?

The work then moved through three layers.

1. Buyer-profile scoring

Each profile was scored on planning friction, SLM fit, upside, buying dynamics, data value, outcomes accessibility, speed to proof, signaling value, replicability, and risk.

2. Representative target testing

Representative organizations were scored inside each profile to test whether the category was actually deep or only looked attractive because of a few strong names.

3. Profile-adjusted ordering

Final ordering combined:

- theoretical profile score
- representative target mean
- target density
- outlier robustness
- confidence

This made the result more disciplined than either TAM-first reasoning or intuition alone.

COMMERCIAL READ

- Closed-loop intermediaries: likely ACV \$250K-\$750K; rough TAM \$50M-\$105M
- Employer-connected workforce intermediaries: likely ACV \$200K-\$500K; rough TAM \$18M-\$45M
- Community college pathways: likely ACV \$150K-\$350K; rough TAM \$35M-\$75M
- Large employers: likely ACV \$500K-\$1.5M+; rough TAM \$750M-\$2B
- Higher-ed with co-op / externship closure: likely ACV \$200K-\$500K; rough TAM \$19M-\$60M
- State workforce systems: likely ACV \$500K-\$1.5M+; rough TAM \$38M-\$60M

The commercial picture reinforces the sequencing logic. The first lane does not need to be the largest lane. It needs to be the one that best compounds into larger lanes later.

BUYER PROFILE APPENDIX

1. Closed-Loop Talent Transformation and Placement Intermediaries

Best for: first proof environment

Limiting factor: moderate integration complexity, but manageable

Representative targets: Revature, SkillStorm, Dev10, Wiley Edge, Smoothstack, FDM Group, Multiverse, LaunchCode, Apprenti, mthree, Catalyte

Likely economic buyers: CEO, COO, CRO, GM of workforce solutions

Likely champions: head of strategy, head of talent transformation, product or platform lead for matching / workforce intelligence

2. Employer-Connected Mission and Workforce Intermediaries

Best for: bridge market after proof

Limiting factor: more variable budget strength and loop closure

Representative targets: Year Up / YUPRO, Per Scholas, NPower, Genesys Works, Merit America, Opportunity@Work, STRIVE, Workforce Opportunity Services, Braven, SkillUp Coalition

Likely economic buyers: CEO, COO, EVP of employer solutions, head of talent networks

Likely champions: head of employer partnerships, head of program strategy, innovation or impact lead, outcomes lead

4. Large Employers with Strategic Workforce Planning Pain

Best for: scale market after proof

Limiting factor: harder outcomes-data access, heavier integration, more bespoke motions

Representative targets: Accenture, Deloitte, Cognizant, Infosys, JPMorgan Chase, Bank of America, Capital One, IBM, Microsoft, Salesforce, Amazon, Walmart

Likely economic buyers: CHRO, Chief Learning Officer, COO, Chief Strategy Officer

Likely champions: workforce planning lead, talent intelligence lead, internal mobility lead, people analytics lead, AI transformation lead

5. Higher-Ed Institutions with Co-op and Externship Outcome Closure

Best for: selective institutional expansion

Limiting factor: narrower category, more outlier dependence

Representative targets: Northeastern, Drexel, University of Cincinnati, Wentworth,

Kettering, Purdue Polytechnic, Georgia Tech, RIT, Stevens, WPI

Likely economic buyers: provost, dean of career-integrated learning, VP for strategy or innovation

Likely champions: career services leader, experiential learning leader, institutional research lead, dean of applied programs

6. State Workforce Agencies and Systems

Best for: long-run infrastructure lane

Limiting factor: procurement drag, governance complexity, slower proof cycles

Representative targets: Virginia, South Carolina, North Carolina, Indiana, Colorado, Tennessee, Texas, California, Ohio, Michigan workforce systems

Likely economic buyers: commissioner or secretary of labor / workforce, chief workforce officer, executive talent-system lead

Likely champions: workforce strategy lead, labor-market intelligence lead, apprenticeship lead, planning or innovation deputy

CLOSING

The key decision is straightforward. The Frontier Model SLM should begin where proof is strongest, feedback is richest, and GTM learning is most repeatable. That starting lane is closed-loop talent transformation and placement intermediaries.

The sequence after that should broaden proof into workforce-system legitimacy, then expand into institutional pathways, then scale into enterprise and eventually infrastructure markets.